CONTENDERS

KYE PETERSON

Location: Vail, Colorado Photos: Chris O'Connell

Age: 13
Residing: Whistler, British Columbia
Sponsors: Rossignol, Oakley, Leki, Giro, Stunt Wax, SSC, Jib Culture

You have a pretty cool name. What does it mean?

It means "ocean" in Hawai'ian. My dad got it from a book he was reading while my mom was pregnant with me. Most people spell it K-A-I, but my dad decided to spell it K-Y-E because he thought it looked more masculine.

So it isn't short for "Mortechai?"

Nope.

On the subject of your dad, what's it like growing up in the town where he was a bona fide skiing and mountaineering legend?

People who were friends with my dad are always coming over to hang out and take me into the backcountry. It's awesome. A lot of the young people here know me because of who my dad was, so that's pretty cool, too.

Have any of the pros you ride with made an effort to take you under their wing?

[Chris] Turpin and [Jon] Reedy have taught me tons of stuff and made me a better skier. Ryan Oakden and the Jib Culture crew have helped me a lot, too. I like to ski with a mix of people, so when I'm not with the older guys I'm with the SSC or Seven Season Crew from school.

How old were you when you slid your first rail, pulled your first 360, and tried your first inverted trick?

Vinnie [Dorion] and Philou [Porrier] taught me how to slide rails at SMS Ski Camp ... I think that was during the summer of 2000, so I was like ten. I learned backflips and backflip 180s around the same time. I don't know when I pulled my first 360, but I think it was the year before.

You often compete against athletes who are twice your age. Is that intimidating?

It's good for me to go up against them. Even though I might not win, I can push myself and compare my skill level to what they're doing. But right now I prefer freeriding ... I'm not really a competition skier just yet. Hopefully I'll get better at competing in the future.

There was a crop of youngsters competing at the 2003 U.S. Freeskiing Open. Can we expect a bigger turnout of bite-sized athletes in 2004?

Definitely. I'm trying to convince a bunch of my friends to enter the Open. A few of them are really good ... and really small. I think being small helps your skiing because you have a lower center of gravity. Being really young helps, too. You aren't as scared to do tricks when you're young. I guess that's probably because you haven't experienced the feeling of pain ... yet.—**JF**